The Jain Religion

The term Jain is derived from *Jina* meaning the victor, or the conqueror—implying conquest or final victory over the bondage of the ailments and ills of life. The ideal or the supreme purpose of Jainism is, therefore, the realization of the highest or the Absolute perfection of the nature of man, which in its original purity is free from all kinds of pain or bondage. Jainism does not consider it necessary to recognize any other perfect being besides man or any being more perfect than the perfect man. It is thus a religion of the perfect man. A being higher than the most perfect man is not considered necessary for either the creation of the world or the moral regulation of the universe. It is for this reason that Jainism is usually characterized as atheistic. But the term with its fixed connotation in Western thought, is likely to be misleading here. It is true that Jainism has no place for a god as a creator or a governor of the universe, and it would be more accurate to call it a heretical sect of the Vedic faith. Jainism had its origin in a revolt from the tradition and the authority of the Vedas. It is well known that among the early adherents of the Vedic faith, differences, in the course of time, arose on the question of animal sacrifice or the killing of animals for the sake of *Yajna.* The *Ahimsā Dharma* and its opposite had a theological tussle from the earliest time. And though the Jain tradition claims its faith to be eternal, it is more than likely that its earliest founders must have belonged to the sect that rebelled from the idea and practice of taking life. It is interesting to note that in the traditional line of the Vedas, those on the side of animal killing are all *Brāhmaṇas,* while the dissenters belong to the *Kshatriya,* or the warrior class, and that the perfect souls, or *Tirthānkaras,* of Jainism are all *Kshatriyas.* Jainism should, therefore, be characterized as a heretical sect of the Vedas, with predominantly monastic leanings, though its teachings are enjoined on all alike. Its peculiar genius lies in its emphasis on